

Google beats Facebook to acquire drone-maker Titan Aerospace

Global search engine giant Google has acquired Titan Aerospace, a company that makes solar-powered drones and was in acquisition talks with Facebook just a few months ago. The Wall Street Journal reports that Google hopes to use the technology provided by Titan to assist its Project Loon project, which aims to connect people to the Internet in far flung areas.

"Titan Aerospace and Google share a profound optimism about the potential for technology to improve the world," a Google spokesman said in a statement. What this means is that very soon, solar-powered drones will deliver Internet connectivity to remote areas, a.k.a. Internet-in-the-sky! Facebook was also in talks to acquire Titan Aerospace earlier; however, all that it has for now is Ascenta, a British company that makes a similar type of drone.

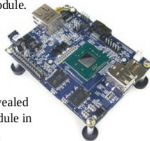


Courtesy the technology provided by Titan Aerospace, Facebook wanted solar-powered drones to deliver sky-based Internet access initially in Africa with 11,000 Solara 60 UAVs. The plan would certainly have been a stepping stone in Facebook's Internet.org efforts to expand online access in developing countries. Instead, Google will be using the technology now for its ambitious Project Loon.

Raspberry Pi hits a high note with the 'mini' Compute Module

The Raspberry Pi Foundation has unveiled a new module, in which the Raspberry Pi's BCM2835 processor and 512 MB of RAM, coupled with 4 GB of storage, are integrated onto a board that fits into the space of a tiny DDR2 memory stick. Pi's new Compute Module will allow circuit board developers to attach desirable interfaces into the small standard connector of the module.

The Compute Module bids adieu to the age-old tradition of using the built-in ports on a conventional Pi design. The module will come along with a starter IO board and is expected to be launched sometime during June this year. There's still no word about the pricing; however, folks back at Raspberry Pi have revealed that large scale buyers like educators can buy the module in batches of 100 at a price of around US\$ 30 per piece.



Microsoft's WinJS goes open source

In a bid to aid developers in quickly and efficiently building cross-platform applications, Microsoft has now open sourced its 'WinJS' JavaScript library for building Windows-like Web applications for other browsers and platforms, including Chrome, Firefox, Android, and iOS. This will save developers from coding the same app multiple times for non-Windows platforms and browsers.

WinJS is a collection of JavaScript tools that give developers advanced components (for data binding, etc) and user interface controls (ListView, FlipView, animations and semantic zoom) with which they can minimise the changes. Microsoft first released the WinJS JavaScript library in 2011 to help developers build Windows applications both for Windows Phone and the Windows 8 Modern interfaces.

Microsoft, Dell sign patent deal on Android, Chrome

Tech giants Microsoft and Dell have signed a 'patent cross-licensing deal', under which Microsoft will get royalties



from Dell on sales of devices that are powered by Google's Android or Chrome software. Microsoft believes that Android can conflict with its patents, and this deal will work to protect its interests. The company has already signed similar deals with other big players like Samsung.

Acknowledging the fierce competition, Microsoft has secured itself against Google's open source platforms by asking the device makers to pay their Microsoft licence fee. Most mobile phone makers like Samsung, LG and HTC have agreed to pay royalties to the Windows maker.

Here's an open source alternative to Siri and Google Now!

Well, looks like Siri, Google Now and Cortana have met their match in Jasper. While the aforementioned technologies are awesome in their own right, none can compete with the open source technology that Jasper brings to the table. Also, it has the very humble Raspberry Pi at its core, an even bigger reason to rejoice!

Jasper is an open source platform for developing always-on, voice-controlled applications that has been created by Princeton students Charles Mash and Shubhro Saha. All that Jasper needs is a working Internet connection, a Raspberry Pi board and a USB microphone, and you'll get a complete open source system that can easily be customised for your needs. Being open source, you can build it yourself with off-the-shelf hardware, and use the online documentation to write your own modules.